Exact Escape Times of Langton's Ant in Four Rows

A finite persistent-response classification and an all-width certificate

Hao Ke

26 October 2026 — Version 0.1.0

Abstract

For the classical white-right, black-left Langton ant, let $S_{4,n}$ be the maximum first-exit time from a four-row, n-column rectangle, over all initial colors and all internal positions and headings. We give a computer-assisted proof of the exact formula $S_{4,n} = 34n - 150$ for every $n \geq 13$, and determine all smaller values. In particular this proves Etse's four-row conjecture $S_{4,n} \leq 34n$. The reduction uses persistent same-side response protocols, not resettable gadgets: every colored block, of arbitrary width, belongs to one of 269 response types for each side and parity. Closure under adjoining a column is checked exhaustively. A weighted refinement with 21,248 query states covers both possible locations of the initial head and gives an exact recurrence. Integer inequalities and tight edges certify the recurrence's affine behavior for all widths beyond a finite base. Independent literal replays supplement, but do not replace, these all-width arguments. The result solves a finite-domain escape question; it does not prove the unrestricted Highway Conjecture.

1 The exact question and answer

The ant moves on $\mathbb{Z}^2$. At a white cell it turns right, changes the cell to black and moves forward by one unit; at a black cell it turns left, changes the cell to white and moves. Headings N,E,S,W are $0, 1, 2, 3$. A state at time t is observed before update t. For

$$R_n = \{0, \ldots, n-1\} \times \{0, 1, 2, 3\},$$

the first-exit time counts the update that moves the head out of R_n. The quantity $S_{4,n}$ is maximized over all 2^{4n} colorings, all $4n$ starting cells and all four headings. Colors outside R_n are arbitrary and remain unread and unchanged before this first exit. No boundary reflection or rule change is imposed.

Theorem 1. *The small values are*

n	*1*	*2*	*3*	*4*	*5*	*6*	*7*	*8*	*9*	*10*	*11*	*12*
$S_{4,n}$	*2*	*18*	*28*	*46*	*64*	*86*	*104*	*146*	*156*	*206*	*224*	*266*

For every $n \geq 13$*,*

$$S_{4,n} = 34n - 150. \tag{1}$$

Every maximum is attained by a complete finite coloring and an effectively reconstructible internal pose.

Etse [1] asks whether $S_{4,n} \le 34n$ in Conjecture 11 of the published MFCS version, Section 4.3.3, p. 49:14. The adjoining text and Figure 13 give lower constructions of size $34n - 150$ for $n \ge 14$ and finite experimental agreement. The full arXiv version numbers this as Conjecture 13. Theorem 1 proves the conjectured upper bound and establishes the exact maximum for every width. Etse already supplied the lower-bound family and finite-width computations; the new step is a complete persistent-interface classification and an all-width upper certificate. Our attainment construction and small-width checks make the resulting exact classification reproducible. The coefficient 34 is consequently optimal. The first-exit convention agrees with [1]; our reduction includes all internal poses and does not rely on a boundary-start lemma.

The finite checks below certify an explicit compositional closure and an elementary integer induction. These are the two bridges from finite data to the all-width theorem.

2 Persistent one-sided responses

Put $\epsilon = (h - x - y) \bmod 2$. Each update changes both heading parity and cell parity, so ϵ is invariant. At column x write $p = x + \epsilon \bmod 2$. The two allowed rows for a horizontal entry are

$$I_p = (1 - p, 3 - p), \qquad U_p = (p, p + 2)$$

is the pair of rows for a horizontal exit. Each list has channels $0, 1$. The outgoing rows from parity p are exactly the incoming rows of a neighboring column with parity $1 - p$. A four-cell column is represented by the mask $b = \sum_{y=0}^{3} \mathbf{1}_{\text{black}}(y) 2^y$.

Fix a block and one of its sides, called the near side: $s = 0$ for left and $s = 1$ for right. A caller may repeatedly choose one of the two incoming channels at this side. Each request initiates a literal excursion until the head exits the block. A near-side exit returns its channel and the behavior of the entire resulting coloring. A top, bottom or far-side exit is terminal. The coloring is never reset between requests.

Definition 2. A finite response type is a pair $t = (\rho_0, \rho_1)$, where $\rho_i = \perp$ or $\rho_i = (j, t')$. Its rank is

$$r(t) = \max(\{0\} \cup \{1 + r(t') : \rho_i = (j, t')\}).$$

The empty block has type $t_0 = (\perp, \perp)$.

We do not assume in advance that every physical block has a finite response type. This will follow from a checked closed algebra. A type forgets the duration and the distinction among terminal sides, since there can be no subsequent request after a terminal. It retains every channel and residual response after a successful return. It is observational equivalence for this interface, *not* equality of full physical colorings. It does not authorize deleting any black cell. Durations are reintroduced in Section 4.

2.1 Adjoining a column

Suppose a near column has mask b, parity p, and a child block has near side s, parity $1 - p$, and type r. Denote the combined type by $\Phi_{s,p}(b, r)$. A literal one-column excursion takes at most two updates: a horizontal incoming heading makes a vertical move and then a horizontal move, unless a vertical boundary has already been crossed; a vertical incoming heading leaves horizontally in one update. Thus its transition table is an exact finite table.

For a parent request execute this one-column table. A vertical exit terminates. A near exit returns its channel, with residual product $\Phi_{s,p}(b', r')$. A far exit enters the child at its corresponding channel. A terminal child answer terminates the parent. Otherwise retain both the changed column mask and the child's returned residual type, reenter the column from its far side and continue. Each successful child call lowers its rank. A proposed finite product table is checked against these equations; on a parent return, the resulting type must be exactly the declared residual product and have smaller rank than the parent type.

Proposition 3 (Finite closure certificate)**.** *For each $(s, p) \in \{0, 1\}^2$ there are 269 distinct canonical response types. They include t_0, have ranks at most 13, and are closed under all 16 column masks and all 269 child types. All $4 \cdot 16 \cdot 269 = 17,216$ product cases are verified for both input channels. The realized type sets by width have sizes*

width	*0*	*1*	*2*	*3*	*4*	*5*	*6*	*7*	*8*
size	*1*	*12*	*36*	*83*	*158*	*240*	*264*	*269*	*269*

The sets at widths seven and eight are equal, not merely equinumerous. Every catalog type has a physical representative of width at most seven.

Proof and infinite-width interpretation. The finite facts are checked by the supplied reconstruction and independent verifier. Nodes are canonical pairs of terminal or channel/child responses; acyclicity and ranks are checked. Product equations are verified by literal one-column updates, preserving the child's residual state. For coverage, induct on width. The empty block has t_0. Every wider coloring is exactly a near column and a smaller colored block. By the induction hypothesis the latter has its exact response type. The checked equations therefore simulate the real parent and establish its exact residual type. Ranks make every request and every permitted series of returns finite. The closed table ensures the result stays in the catalog for every width. The displayed representatives, independently replayed as complete response trees, prove realizability. Distinct canonical trees have some finite request sequence distinguishing them. Thus the catalog is exact for the stated interface. □

This proof allows an arbitrarily long colored block and arbitrarily many proposed requests. It concludes that at most 13 of those requests can return successfully. It never treats the inside of a block as blank after return. The rank 13 is attained under a suitable compatible caller schedule.

3 A local bound independent of width

Consider a column at its first visit during a rectangle-confined run. Its left and right parts have arbitrary complete colorings, possibly modified by earlier motion, and hence have exact catalog types. Replace an excursion into either side by its persistent response. A return lowers the sum of the two ranks. Between responses there are at most two central-column updates. This product terminates without any assumption on the widths of the side blocks.

Proposition 4 (Sharp column and cut bounds)**.** *Before first escape from any four-row rectangle, a fixed column is updated at most 34 times. A vertical cut is crossed at most 21 times. Both bounds are attained.*

Proof. The central-column check enumerates the two parities, all pairs of 269 side types, 16 masks, and eight compatible internal row/heading poses: exactly $2 \cdot 269^2 \cdot 16 \cdot 8 = 18,524,416$ cases. The

largest local count is 34. The two-block cut handshake enumerates 578,888 cases, counting the first entry crossing; its largest count is 21. Each internal return lowers a checked rank, so these are exhaustive finite products, not truncated simulations. For sharpness of the column bound, the masks

$$(15, 9, 9, 9, 7, 1, 11, 6, 6, 6, 0)$$

with head $(5, 1)$ facing west give 159 total updates and exactly 34 in column 5. The explicit cut witness is included in the report. Its source is obtained by one literal inverse update before the first entry, so all 21 crossings occur in one real autonomous run. Complete endpoints are checked. □

Summing column counts proves $S_{4,n} \leq 34n$ immediately. This already resolves the published conjecture. It does not yet give the subtractive constant 150, because maximal column behaviors need not be simultaneously attainable. The next reduction addresses precisely that compatibility issue.

4 An exact weighted recurrence

The duration of a block cannot be maximized independently on each call: the same coloring must persist across all of them. We retain the whole finite request script in a weighted query.

An *ordinary query* $F(p, t, q)$ specifies parity p, response type t and a finite channel word q. All requests except possibly its last must return; the last may return or terminate. Let F_n be the maximum total updates of this script over all width-n colorings of type t. If no such coloring exists, the value is $-\infty$. The empty script has zero cost only when its type is realizable at that width. Relevant scripts have at most 14 requests.

A *rooted descriptor* o is terminal or a pair (j, t): the first run starts somewhere inside the block and either terminates or returns at channel j, leaving ordinary type t. There are $1 + 2 \cdot 269 = 539$ descriptors per parity. A rooted query $R(p, o, q)$ performs this initial run followed by q. If o is terminal, q is empty. Its value maximizes over all complete colorings and all internal starting poses realizing that descriptor.

4.1 Complete decomposition rules

For an ordinary query enumerate every (b, r) with $\Phi_{0,p}(b, r) = t$. Run the parent script symbolically through that column and its child's exact response tree. The result is a local count c and a child script q'. This is an edge to $F(1 - p, r, q')$ of weight c.

For a rooted query there are two, and only two, possible locations for the root. If it is in the new column, enumerate all eight compatible poses, the mask and the child's ordinary type, run the initial excursion, then the parent script. The successor query is ordinary F. If the root is in the child, enumerate its rooted descriptor. A terminal child first run gives a terminal parent without touching the new column. Otherwise its output channel starts the new-column motion. The later calls form the continuation script of a rooted child query R. In both cases count only updates in the new column in c; the child's query counts its entire history exactly once.

The starting goals are all rooted descriptors with empty continuation. Closing these rules backwards yields 21,248 states and 527,764 edges, with 1,078 goals. The graph is finite because the catalog and bounded scripts are finite. The verifier checks every required successor and edge, both root placements, and reachability of every stored state from the goal set.

Let $V_n(v)$ be the resulting value. The recurrence is

$$V_0(v) = \begin{cases} 0, & v = F(p, t_0, q),\ |q| \le 1, \\ -\infty, & \text{otherwise}, \end{cases}$$
$$V_n(v) = \max_{v \xrightarrow{c} u} (c + V_{n-1}(u)). \tag{2}$$

An empty block terminates its first ordinary request without an update and has no internal starting root. These are exactly the stated base cases.

Lemma 5 (Physical exactness)**.** *The values in (2) equal the physical maxima of their queries. Every finite value is attained. Consequently*

$$S_{4,n} = \max_{v \in \mathcal{G}} V_n(v), \tag{3}$$

where $\mathcal{G}$ is the set of all 1,078 goals.

Proof. Induct on width. A real coloring splits into its near-column mask and its actual child. For rooted queries the initial head is either in that column or in the child. These exhaustive alternatives select one enumerated edge. Persistent response equivalence forces the recorded child script, so the time is local weight plus one child query value. This proves the upper inequality. Conversely, take an attaining child configuration for a finite successor value and prepend the edge's recorded column. If appropriate, use its recorded initial pose; otherwise retain the child's root. The exact response equations ensure that all successive calls are made to this same child with its evolving colors. They give the parent duration and descriptor claimed by the edge. This proves attainment and the lower inequality. Maximizing over all rooted outcomes gives (3). No boundary-entry assumption is used. □

For emphasis, omitting the rooted states would solve a different, smaller one-sided-entry problem. Also, separately maximizing each child call would permit incompatible colorings and would not prove this lemma.

5 All-width affine stabilization by local integer inequalities

The recurrence through width 23 is computed exactly. Define integer vectors on all 21,248 states by

$$A = V_{20}, \quad B = V_{21}, \quad d = V_{22} - V_{20}, \quad e = V_{23} - V_{21}.$$

The certificate checks that A and B are finite everywhere. On every edge $v \xrightarrow{c} u$ it verifies

$$B(v) \ge c + A(u), \qquad e(v) \ge d(u), \tag{4}$$
$$A(v) + d(v) \ge c + B(u), \qquad d(v) \ge e(u). \tag{5}$$

For each vertex there is an edge attaining both inequalities in (4), and an edge, possibly different, attaining both in (5). There are 2,111,056 integer inequalities and 42,496 tight-edge existence checks.

Lemma 6 (Explicit affine certificate)**.** *These checked inequalities and tight edges imply, for every $k \ge 0$,*

$$V_{20+2k} = A + kd, \qquad V_{21+2k} = B + ke.$$

Proof. Substitution into (2) gives $B + ke$ as an upper bound by (4); a simultaneously tight edge attains it. Substituting once more, (5) gives and attains $A + (k+1)d$. The base values are the exact computed V_{20}, V_{21}. This proves the assertion by induction, not by an empirical period-detection rule. □

For every goal the checked envelopes are

$$A \le 530, \quad B \le 564, \quad d \le 68, \quad e \le 68.$$

There is a goal with $A = 530, d = 68$ and a goal with $B = 564, e = 68$. Lemma 6 and (3) give $34n - 150$ for all $n \ge 20$. The exact values at widths 13 through 19 and the twelve smaller widths prove Theorem 1.

This is also a constructive lower-bound proof. At each width choose an attaining edge, output its near-column mask and recurse on the child. Exactly one rooted to ordinary transition supplies the initial head. The path ends at a valid empty block base case. Thus every n yields a complete maximizing seed, with n explicit masks. Its reconstruction is an output-sensitive finite algorithm, not a demand to simulate an unbounded run. In particular the asymptotic lower coefficient 34 is established independently of the earlier lower construction.

6 Certificate architecture and independent controls

The supplied code has a Python constructor and a separately written C++17 verifier. The latter reconstructs all column products from its own literal turn/flip rule, checks the response ranks, independently builds the expected edge list at every weighted state, checks completeness of the goal set, and recomputes all dynamic values. It then verifies every inequality and tight-edge obligation. A second Python integer DP repeats the affine-vector calculation and the induction check. No numerical optimization, SMT, Presburger solver or upstream project simulator is used.

The canonical response/graph serialization has SHA256

`3e01b0422cf2d921fb0ed4aaa690d8f89ffacfa92973a25c3aea590ac8d1110b`

and the checked A, B, d, e row serialization has SHA256

`4fb5165094326189694eb227157b578497e089f19eff2abed050b14286c27bca`

Readable deterministic reconstruction avoids a large opaque table dump. Hashes pin the exact finite claims; the mathematical verification is the local composition, coverage and integer conditions, not the hash itself.

The scoped verification includes the following distinct controls.

- All 1,076 side/parity-specific representatives have their complete future same-side reply trees compared to direct full-color simulation. Every coloring through width three is checked as well: 17,472 side/parity behaviors.
- Native literal simulation exhausts 4,399,360 coloring/pose inputs through width four, making 20,978,524 updates. It matches the exact maxima but is not the proof for larger widths.

- Twenty-nine reconstructed maximizing seeds, through width 1001, are replayed independently in Python, totaling 89,950 updates. Additional random wide cases and full-plane exterior-marker controls preserve complete fields.
- Altered response data, missing coverage counts, an incorrect recurrence weight and a damaged affine vector are rejected. Resource exhaustion never means a negative answer or an accepted certificate.

The default check runs in a disposable directory and compares a fresh report to a frozen report without overwriting it. Generation is a separate explicit mode. The finite tables and their coverage arguments have not been translated into a formal proof assistant. The trusted base includes the written reductions, the exact verifier source, language implementations and integer execution. Algorithmic independence within one research session is not outside review.

7 Scope, implications and limitations

This completes the exact four-row first-exit problem rather than increasing a simulation cutoff. The finite catalog handles arbitrarily many columns and all possible colorings, and persists under arbitrary compatible return requests. The weighted recurrence then restores the histories needed to solve a genuinely autonomous maximum, without replacing each return by a new independently chosen coloring.

A conditional infinite-strip consequence is worth distinguishing from HC. If any orbit stays forever in an infinite four-row band, each fixed column is updated at most 34 times: every finite prefix can be embedded in a finite rectangle, to which Proposition 4 applies. Hence such a confined orbit is transient, even with an arbitrary infinite initial background. This does not force a general planar orbit into a band and does not identify its future as the standard highway.

The unrestricted Highway Conjecture remains unresolved by this work. An ant can exit the observation rectangle, modify exterior cells, and later reenter. There is no bound here on the number of those episodes, and no old field is removed between them. Higher strip heights are not covered by the 269-type certificate. The method suggests studying their persistent response closure, but no finite closure or universal linear-height theorem is asserted.

The column viewpoint and motivating conjecture are due to Etse [1]. Behavioral minimization, compositional interfaces and weighted dynamic programming are established methods; they are not claimed as inventions here. The new concrete result is the complete four-row response closure and exact all-width maximum, establishing the upper bound suggested by Etse's constructions and computations.

A Reproduction and witness format

From the repository root run

```
python3 four_row_escape/reproduce.py
```

The only runtime requirements are Python 3.10 or later and a C++17 compiler. The implementation is in `four_row_escape/verification/four_row_boundary/`. The companion proof gives the

precise source/hash boundary and scoped integration instructions. Old project runtimes and unrelated certificates are not rebuilt.

An optional witness export is produced by

```
python3 four_row_escape/verification/four_row_boundary/check.py \
  --witnesses /tmp/four-row-maximizers.txt
```

Each row is `n x y h time mask0 ... mask(n-1)`. A mask's bit y is the initial black color at that row; all other cells are white unless expressly added as exterior controls. The first-exit calculation does not read outside the rectangle. The source also records an attaining 34-update column and an autonomous 21-crossing cut witness.

References

[1] Kossi Roland Etse. How Long Can The Escaping Ant Be Confined? In *51st International Symposium on Mathematical Foundations of Computer Science (MFCS 2026)*, LIPIcs 386, 49:1–49:17, 2026. doi:10.4230/LIPIcs.MFCS.2026.49. Full version: arXiv:2606.26677v1. Published conjecture number 11; preprint conjecture number 13.